

Argentina is one of several low-cost countries you can choose. The dollar buys paradise in parts of Greece, Spain, Mexico, and Brazil. Hungarians and Yugoslavs often earn in the United States and then go back to the "old country" to retire. With a dollar income back there you can lead an extraordinary life, providing you avoid trouble and don't play the Ugly American. In most of the Third World, \$50 a day provides a fabulous standard of living and plenty of time to do what you want: travel, reflect, write, learn something new and slip into an interesting challenge, or simply come up with novel perspectives on life and work.

It's not that living is cheap in the Third World, but that *money* is cheap in the Third World. Locals often struggle to subsist. Tell them that the cost of living is low and they'll think the cheese has slipped off your cracker. But with dollars in your pocket, instead of pesos, florins, or dinars, you can live far better than in the United States. You earned and paid taxes in dollars. You did it in the richest country in the world. You were fortunate. When you retire, you can spend some of your wealth in the economies of the less fortunate.

The dollar goes a long way in the Third World regardless of whether the dollar happens to be "up" or "down" at the moment. The United States trades mainly with Canada, Japan, and Western Europe, not with Yugoslavia, Costa Rica, and Thailand. When we say the dollar is "down" we mean it buys fewer yen, pounds, or francs. But the dollar is invariably "up" in Third World countries. That's because those countries export low-cost farm produce and import high-value airplanes, machine tools, and computers. Because of that imbalance, Third World countries are starved for hard currency. To encourage exports and reduce imports, they "compete" by devaluing their money—again and again and again.

Some of this seems unfair. Libraries set aside whole sections of material on terms of trade between the rich and the poor. But Third World countries keep their currencies low precisely to attract dollars. When you move to those countries